

# Introduction: Appraising Concepts

While much philosophy strives to give us a firmer hold on our concepts, we sometimes also find ourselves questioning their hold on us: why should we place ourselves under their sway and grant them the authority to shape our thought and conduct?<sup>1</sup> The concepts we use render us sensitive to the reasons that guide and flow from their application. But what reasons do we have to heed those reasons in the first place? If our thoughts were cast in different terms, they would advert to different reasons, carry different implications, and set us on different trajectories. Concepts may be immutable, but our conceptualizations are not. By changing our conceptualizations—the ways of thinking and valuing in virtue of which we possess the concepts we do—we can change *which* concepts we use. Do the concepts we currently use merit the confidence with which we draw on them? What makes one concept better than another?

The question matters, because not every issue, in philosophy or elsewhere, consists simply in figuring out what is true or what is justified given the way we conceptualize things. Many issues are, at least in part, about how to conceptualize things—how to carve things up, how to characterize them, and what significance to attach to them. People can form perfectly true and justified judgements and nonetheless attract criticism for the very terms in which they think.

Questioning the terms in which we think goes to the root of our thinking processes, for while the judgements we form might be criticized as false or unwarranted, these criticisms still take for granted the conceptual framework within which those judgements are articulated. By contrast, appraising the concepts we use goes one step further, asking whether things might not go better if we used different concepts that put alternative sets of judgements and

<sup>1</sup> The question is significantly different from the Kantian, semantic concern to understand how concept application can be liable to assessments of correctness that Robert Brandom, drawing a *prima facie* similar chiasmic contrast, sees as replacing the Cartesian, epistemological concern with whether our ideas are clear and distinct: 'For Kant the question is . . . how to understand [concepts'] grip on us: the conditions of the intelligibility of our being bound by conceptual norms' (2009, 33); see also Brandom (1994, 9–11; 2000, 80; 2002a, 22; 2019b, 9). My question is not *how any* concepts can bind us, but *why these* concepts rather than others should be allowed to.